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Treat Soft things, Hard.

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Hello, Curious Minds!

When was the last time you gave a casual coffee chat, a team celebration, or even a quick thank-you note the same importance as a big presentation or a pitch?

We often categorize tasks as “soft” (like building relationships or having informal conversations) and “hard” (like hitting numbers or closing deals).

But here’s the truth:

the so-called “soft” things are what make the hard things work.

Let’s dive into why treating soft things seriously can transform how we work, lead, and grow.

1. What Does “Treat Soft Things, Hard” Mean?

It’s about being intentional with the little things that often get overlooked—like truly listening, fostering inclusivity, or making time for meaningful conversations. These aren’t “nice-to-haves.” They’re essential for

building trust, collaboration, and lasting impact.

For me, it means making space for:

- **Coffee Chats:** Casual check-ins that strengthen connections.
 - **Diverse Perspectives:** Encouraging every voice to be heard.
 - **Clear Communication:** Simplifying ideas to ensure alignment.
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2. My Experience with This

A few years ago, I realized I was focusing too much on outcomes and not enough on relationships. When I shifted my approach, even small changes—like scheduling coffee chats, celebrating team wins, or being a better listener—led to stronger connections and smoother teamwork.

One of my favorite examples is how a simple, informal discussion over coffee with a leader turned into something much more impactful. What started as a casual chat evolved into a meaningful connection that benefited not just me, my work but also my life & larger teams.

Through these conversations, I gained valuable mentors, created a safe space to share informal feedback, and built connections that continue to shape my journey. These interactions often grew into regular cadences, driving positive change and fostering collaboration for the greater good.

It taught me a powerful lesson: treating these “soft” moments with intention often leads to outcomes far beyond what we imagine.

3. Why It Works

Treating soft things seriously:

- **Builds Trust:** People feel valued and understood.
 - **Boosts Collaboration:** Small gestures create stronger bonds, making teamwork effortless.
 - **Drives Results:** A connected, engaged team delivers better outcomes.
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4. How You Can Do This

Here are simple ways to treat soft things hard:

1. **Be a Super Communicator:** Simplify complex ideas. Take time to really listen during conversations.
 2. **Make Time for Small Gestures:** Schedule a coffee chat to check in with someone. Send a quick “thank you” or “great job” message (*bonus: highlighting specifics of what you liked!*)
 3. **Celebrate Diversity:** Invite different perspectives in discussions. Recognize contributions from all corners of the team.
 4. **Be Deliberate with Relationships:** Treat every interaction—no matter how small—as an opportunity to connect meaningfully.
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Your Turn

YOUR TURN

This week, think about:

- What "soft" task can you treat with more seriousness?
- How can you use conversations, gratitude, or inclusivity to create a bigger impact?

I'd love to hear your stories—whether it's about a coffee chat, a kind word, or a moment when relationships made the difference. Let's keep growing together!

Until next time, stay curious, Vikas Surani signing off.

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